

St. Joseph the All-Comely Orthodox Texas Prison Ministry Newsletter

Number 12, Feb 15/ Feb 28 2021

Contact Info.....	1
A Primer for the Christian Beginning to Lead a Spiritual Life – 40-45.....	1
Prison Ministry News.....	1
Questions and Answers.....	1
Can “Ordinary” People be saved, or only monastics and martyrs?.....	1
Latter-day Christians will do fewer miracles and yet be Greater than the Holy Desert Fathers	4
Are there saints commemorated who lived “ordinary lives” as husbands and wives and children?	4
St. Anthony and the Cobbler	4
St Anthony and the righteous doctor.....	5
Two righteous women who were wives and mothers.....	5
Do you want to be a saint? Do not go mad as the world calls you mad.	5
Two Married saints	5
The “Old” and “New” Calendar	5
Are bishops all “equal” in the Orthodox Church?.....	5
“Is there no union/communion between the different Orthodox faiths?”	6
Comparing Roman Catholic vs. Orthodox practices.....	6
A Word from Fr David	6
“Grant Us, O Lord, to Make a Good Beginning...”	6
O Lord and Master of my life	7
Prayer of St Ephrem <i>explained</i>	7

http://www.orthodox.net/prison-ministry/newsletter-012_2021-02-28+can-ordinary-people-be-saints+prayer-of-st-ephrem.doc http://www.orthodox.net/prison-ministry/newsletter-012_2021-02-28+can-ordinary-people-be-saints+prayer-of-st-ephrem.html http://www.orthodox.net/prison-ministry/newsletter-012_2021-02-28+can-ordinary-people-be-saints+prayer-of-st-ephrem.pdf

Note: With God helping us, we will send many newsletters to all those we minister to in prison. We aim to send a newsletter least twice each month. This is the 12th sent to 79 souls. Those who wish to contribute to our material needs in our ministry to Orthodox Christians may help us with donations at <http://www.orthodox.net/ministries/orthodox-prison-ministry.html>

Contact Info

Patriarch Joseph the All-Comely Texas ORTHODOX Prison Ministry
<http://www.orthodox.net/ministries/orthodox-prison-ministry.html>

Priest Seraphim Holland seraphim@orthodox.net, St. Nicholas Russian Orthodox Church, PO Box 37, McKinney, TX 75070

Priest Cassian Sibley rcassian@yahoo.com, Theotokos of the Life-Giving Spring Russian Orthodox Mission, 1009 Winter Street, Bryan, TX 77803

Priest David Companik davidcompanik@gmail.com, St. Jonah Orthodox Church, PO Box 1427, Spring, TX 77383

NOTE: Fr. David manages our ministry's distribution of Orthodox books, church calendars, icons, and service texts. Contact him if you need anything.

A Primer for the Christian Beginning to Lead a Spiritual Life – 40-45

41. Every evening, confess to God all your sinful thoughts, words, and deeds. (Also, record them so that you remember what to confess to your spiritual father.)

42. Before you go to sleep, make peace with all, prostrating yourself before anyone you have offended.

43. Do not tell others about your dreams. (That does not include your spiritual father.)

44. Prayer said at night is of greater value than prayer said during the day.

45. Cross yourself before you go to sleep.

Prison Ministry News

Fr Seraphim signed the contract for the property in Marshall.

We expect to close in March.

Questions and Answers

Can “Ordinary” People be saved, or only monastics and martyrs?

"I watched some of your videos where you described the lives of Martyrs/Saints, why we should pray to them, and how they earned their way into the Kingdom of Heaven. ... All of the examples I encounter are about the ascetic people (people who live in the wilderness, desert) or monks. "My question: is it possible to earn a way into heaven (even become Holy?) by living an "ordinary" life? What I mean by ordinary life: living in the house/apartment, going to work, raising kids, doing a family routine, going to /church every Sun/confession/fast/pray every day/help other people/tithing, etc.

"I got the impression that the only way to heaven/holiness is to "stop everything that we're doing" and go in the wilderness. In some exceptional cases, terrible circumstances happen (like persecution/torture) where a person can accept it, struggle, and be rewarded. But I don't think nowadays it's a reality for "most people." Despite that, are there any Saints who lived in the regular household?"

Any person may find the Kingdom of heaven living a so-called "ordinary" life! Of course, by "ordinary," I do not mean ordinary according to the way people in the world live or even how most Christians live.

The Lord said that the way to paradise is narrow: "... Strait is the gate, and narrow is the way, which leadeth unto life, and few there be that find it." (Mat 7:14) He did not say that it is exclusive to monastics and great ascetics and martyrs. The way to live that brings eternal life is identically the same for monastics, martyrs, and laypeople. We must live with intensity, and honesty, and repentance, and fasting, and prostrations, and a regular prayer rule, and intercession for others as a priority, and the attendance of all the services that it is possible to attend according to one's station in life, and all the other exercises of true Christianity. There is nothing keeping anybody from doing these things if they are married or unmarried or have a demanding occupation, travel, are imprisoned, or any other station in life.

If we live in this way, we are not living an "ordinary" life. We are living an *extraordinary* life, with the Holy Spirit abiding in our hearts and assisting us in prayer with groanings that cannot be uttered¹.

The Forerunner and Baptist John taught that anyone could be saved. He was very explicit in his instructions. Your question is one that many people have asked because we have this failing as human beings that we think that for something to be important, it must be extraordinary according to some vague definition of the word. It is extraordinary for *any* person to live with zeal, and love, and purpose. Here is the dialogue that St. John had with those who came to be baptized.

"And the people asked him, saying, What shall we do then? [Note: They were frightened by his prophecies, and were asking how they can be saved because his words seemed very difficult for them] (11) He answereth and saith unto them, He that hath two coats, let

him impart to him that hath none; and he that hath meat, let him do likewise. (12) Then came also publicans to be baptized, and said unto him, Master, what shall we do? (13) And he said unto them, Exact no more than that which is appointed you. (14) And the soldiers likewise demanded of him, saying, And what shall we do? And he said unto them, Do violence to no man, neither accuse any falsely; and be content with your wages." Luke 3:10-14

The Holy Prophet is clearly indicating that ordinary people can be saved and indeed will be saved. They must live a moral life. They must struggle and be kind and aware of others' needs, with almsgiving, and honesty, and in general all of the Christian virtues as best that one can practice them. All of this is possible and more than possible for the man who prays and fasts and does prostrations and all other Christian exercises.

Christianity is an ascetic life. We must be ascetics, but we are not required to go out into the desert or into barren land to be ascetics. **Asceticism is the denial of ourselves for a higher purpose.** The Lord speaks of this asceticism when He tells us: "Whosoever will come after me, let him deny himself, and take up his cross, and follow me." (Mark 8:34, Cf. Mat 16:24, Luke 9:23)

The world teaches an "anti-ascetic" life. Even in Orthodox churches, there is anti-asceticism. Some Orthodox Christians have the audacity, arrogance, and ignorance to say that asceticism is only for monks, and fasting is only for monks, and that they do not have time to pray because of their daily duties. Don't believe these lies! People indulge themselves, not fasting regularly or at all and being lazy in other ways. All these things are the way of death.

I want my words to comfort everyone who is in what they consider to be an "ordinary life." I also want them to be frightening to those who are lazy or who have not developed a good prayer rule, or do not fast or don't go to services very often.

The only way that we can live a transcendent life is with the grace of God helping us. The grace of God is likened to water in the Scriptures. Water is life-giving, but only to those who are prepared for it. If a farmer does not plow his land, and amend it with mulch, and remove the weeds when the rain comes, it will not be of any benefit because it will run off the hard ground into the gutter, or it will feed the weeds which will choke out the growth of the grain. Our soul is like ground that is meant to produce fruit. We must struggle to have that ground be prepared for the coming of the grace of God so that it soaks deeply into us. We do this by prayer and all of the other Christian exercises. We do this by being very sober. We do this by turning away from worldly things and worldly entertainment.

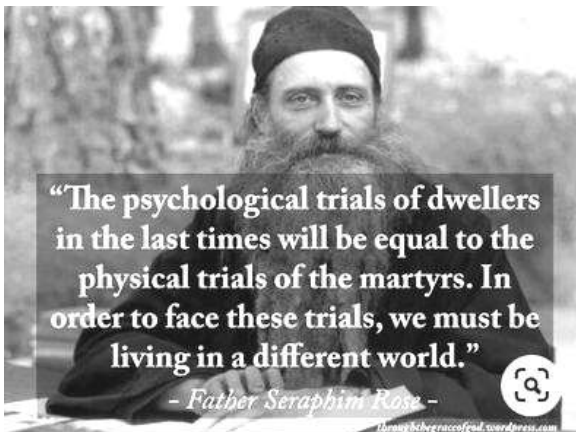
I do not mean that we cannot watch a movie or go on vacation with our family. I mean that in our daily life, we focus on the things that are needful. There is nothing keeping anyone from focusing on these things, no matter what their life situation. The only thing that keeps us from focusing

on these things is ourselves. Perhaps we have passions that interfere, or we are distracted by the world or lazy. These things can be changed. We change them with repentance and effort. We change them by going to the priest and confessing and listening to his counsel. We change them by partaking in the Holy Mysteries as we are able. We change them by a daily prayer rule, which, if we do not follow it well at first, as we continue in our efforts, we will become better.

The purpose of our life is to attain the perfection of the soul so that we will attain the likeness of God and know Him intimately; it is exactly the same purpose as any ascetic or monastic or martyr. There is no difference in the purpose of life for any human being.

We should take the wise teaching of St. John the Baptist very seriously. We have no excuses. We live our life exactly where we live it. There is no waiting for another better place to live. The place and conditions in which we live our lives now and the duties and responsibilities we have are fully compatible with striving for perfection, with God's grace helping us.

Addendum. The question mentioned some of the videos that I have made that refer to martyrs who did extraordinary things. The vast majority of those martyrs were those that had made a grave mistake or had apostatized but had repented, and they are now in paradise.



We are living in tough times, and our faith will be tested. It may be tested as the martyrs had their faith tested, but most of the tests will be of a softer variety. The world tells us to live a certain way, and that is a test. Our family may think that we are too intense, and that is a test. Our job supervisors might be offended because we do not have the same moral opinions they do. That is a test. Companies that want us to sign documents as a type of secular confession of faith that contradicts Christian moral life or speak in a "politically correct" way is a test. There is intense pressure to believe the commonly stated/published secular "truth" or "news." That is a test. The entire world has lost its mind regarding sexual morality and identity and what constitutes a meaningful life. That is a test.

We must make sure that we are ready for these tests. They are coming, and for some of us, they have already arrived. This is why I do prostrations every day to many saints that have witnessed their faith after apostasy or severe mistake². We are not saved because we make no mistakes. We are saved because, by the grace of God, we struggle, and God never abandons us, and we find our way, and the Holy Spirit is with us at all times.

I advise everyone to add prostrations to their daily prayers. I know they can be challenging. Sometimes I delay doing my prostrations in the morning because I feel tired or my knees hurt, or I'm just being lazy or allowing myself to be distracted. Those are just "stupid human tricks." We will not be saved by giving in to all of our stupid human tricks. We will be saved by effort.

The small number of prostrations that I do every day is not in any way inferior to those of an ascetic who is living without the distractions of the world. I'm not bragging here. I do not do nearly enough in any aspect of my religious life. I'm confident, however, that the fathers of old taught that those who are subjected to great temptations in the modern-day, even though they do less, will have their repentance accepted by God. I'm in the middle of the world, and therefore I get distracted by it. And I'm not an ascetic in the desert who only eats every third day. I have a family, and I have grandchildren and a parish, and God has put me here to take care of them. And I do the best I can. It's not good enough, but God takes what is not good, but done with a good disposition, and makes it good. We must believe that about our lives.

Do not allow the little that you do prevent you from getting better and doing more. You can do what you can do at this moment in time, and you can always do more than *you think you can do*, or want to do, or are in the habit of doing. The "secret" of the victorious Christian life is to try to do a little bit more, without listening to any inner voices that it is not enough (so why bother), and we always will get better. "... Well done, thou good and faithful servant: thou hast been faithful over a few things, I will make thee ruler over many things: enter thou into the joy of thy lord." (Mat 25:21)

The following saying from one of the Desert fathers applies fully to our discussion. Although it is in a monastic context, if one knows how to read the Holy Fathers, it is easy to see that it applies to all Christians. After reading this quotation, I hope that everyone realizes that they can be saved without going to a faraway barren land or becoming a monastic, or becoming a martyr. They can be saved by enduring temptations and struggling to fulfill the commandments of God. God will count their effort in these benighted times as greater than that of the great fathers of the desert.

Latter-day Christians will do fewer miracles and yet be Greater than the Holy Desert Fathers

The monks asked the great Abba Ischyryon: "What have we done?"

Ischyryon replied: "We have fulfilled the commandments of God,"

The monks asked: "And what will those do who come after us?"

"They will do what we do, but only half as much."

"And those after them?"

"Before the end of time, they will not keep the monastic rule, but such misfortunes and temptations will befall them that, through their patience during those assaults and temptations, they will prove themselves greater than our fathers and us in the Kingdom of God." (Sayings of the Desert Fathers, Abba Ischyryon probably lived in the 4th century, in upper Egypt)

Are there saints commemorated who lived "ordinary lives" as husbands and wives and children?

Yes, there are. They are comparatively fewer in the Menologion (lives of the saints) because people who lead ordinary lives (from the world's perspective) are not well known. This should not bother us because, in heaven, all the saints are very well known. There are no

ordinary saints in heaven. The following stories are meant to convince you that it is extraordinary to live a Christian life and that Heaven is filled with holy Christians whom the world is forgotten but are known to the Lord and all of the more "famous" saints.

St. Anthony and the Cobbler

St. Anthony the Great once prayed: "Lord, reveal to me how the faithful person in the city among the noise can reach the spiritual level of the ascetic who dwells in the deep desert." He had not even finished this request to the All-good God when he heard a voice tell him:

"The Gospel is the same for all men, Anthony. And if you want to confirm this, how one who does the will of God is saved and sanctified wherever he is, go to Alexandria to the small cobbler's store, which is simple and poor. It is there below the last road of the city."

"To the cobbler's store, Lord? And who there can help shine some light on my thought?" replied the puzzled Saint. "The cobbler will explain to you," replied the same voice.

Anthony wondered "The cobbler? What does this man know about struggles and temptations? What does the poor toiler know of the heights of faith and of the truth?"

His objections, however, could not be straightened by the divine explanation. Because of this, at dawn, he traveled to the city. However, as God had shown him, he stopped at the small cobbler store that he found. Happily and reverently, the simple man welcomed him in and asked him: "In what way could I be of use to you, Abba? I'm an illiterate and uncouth villager, but for the stranger, whoever he is, I will try to help, whatever the need."

"The Lord sent me for you to teach me," replied the ascetic humbly. The poor worker jumped up in wonder. "Me? What could I, the illiterate one, teach your holiness? I don't know if I have done anything good or noteworthy in my life, something which could stand unadulterated before the eyes of God."

"Tell me what you do, how you pass your day. God knows; He weighs and judges things differently," replied

"I, Abba, have never done anything good; I only struggle to keep the holy teachings of the Gospel. And further, I try never to forget to never overlook my shortcomings and my spiritual fruitlessness. Therefore, as I work during the day, I think and say to myself: O wretched man, all will be saved, and only you will remain fruitless. Because of your sin, you will never be worthy to see His Holy Face."

"I thank Thee O Lord," the ascetic said, raising his weeping eyes towards heaven. And as the cobbler remained puzzled at this, the ascetic embraced him with love and bid him farewell saying: "And thank you, O holy man. Thank you, for you taught me how easy it is with only a humble mind, for someone to live in the grace of paradise."

And as the poor cobbler continued to stare uneasily, without at all understanding this, St. Anthony took his staff and departed for the deep desert. He walked, his only companion being the sound of his staff. The Saint walked, and his prayer burned like the sands of the desert, rising towards heaven. He traveled all day and prayerfully reflected on the lesson that he received that day from the poor cobbler.

"Humility! This, therefore, is the quickest path to the gate of paradise," he said in his thoughts. "Humility is the robe which God clothed himself with and came to earth as a man."

He walked and struggled to perceive the greatness of this holy virtue, praying in his nous. He brought to mind whatever God had taught him, until immediately before him he saw thrown underfoot a countless number of traps: Traps of every sort, terrible notions, machinations never before seen. "My God," he exclaimed and turned the frightened eyes of his

soul towards heaven. "Who could ever flee, O Lord, from such traps and ruses?"

"Humility, Anthony. This can singly deliver from all of these." He again heard the sweet, beloved voice deep within his heart. And this was

St Anthony and the righteous doctor

"It was revealed to Abba Anthony in his desert that there was one who was his equal in the city. He was a doctor by profession, and whatever he had beyond his needs, he gave to the poor, and every day he

Two righteous women who were wives and mothers.

One day while meditating, St. Macarius thought that perhaps there were no more righteous people in the world. A voice came from Heaven and said, "In the City of Alexandria, you will find two very righteous women." He took his staff and went to the city. He was guided to the home of the two women, where he inquired of their life. One of them related to him, "There is no kinship between us, and when we married these two brothers, we asked them to leave us to be nuns, but they refused. So we committed ourselves to spend our life fasting until evening, and we pray diligently. When each of us had a son, whenever one of them would cry,

Do you want to be a saint? Do not go mad as the world calls you mad.

"Abba Anthony said, 'A time is coming when men will go mad, and when they see someone who is not mad, they will attack him saying,

Two Married saints

St. Thomaïs of Lesbos was married to an abusive husband, and spent her days in prayer and almsgiving, and was eventually killed by her husband during one of his daily beatings of her. He lost his mind and became insane immediately. On the 40th day (on this day, we always have the service of commemoration for the recently reposed), when he fell on top of the grave, he regained his sanity. He may have been demon-possessed, and the prayers of the saint who was his abused wife drove out the demon. He repented and became a monk. Perhaps someone might

The "Old" and "New" Calendar

"I got the calendar, and I had a question: on each day, there is another date with smaller letters in black or red ink. For example, on February 1, in black, it says 19 Jan. What is the extra date?"

We follow the so-called "Old Calendar," which is 13 days behind the wall calendar, the one some have heard me refer to as "Joe's garage calendar." By that, I mean the civil calendar, the calendar that would be hanging on the wall in Joe's garage or Madge's beauty shop.

The dates you give in your question are, in order, the civil calendar date (Feb 1) and the church calendar date (19 Jan). The church calendar date will always be 13 days behind the civil date. On the calendar that Fr David

Are bishops all "equal" in the Orthodox Church?

"In the Roman Catholic Church when the Cardinals/bishops meet, those of Eastern Rite and Western Rite, both in the Roman Catholic faith, come

the response that instilled light within him and gave him courage for the new battles he experienced within the deep desert with the eternal enemy of man. https://www.facebook.com/Orthodox-Parables-and-Stories-328957564248490/?tn=-UC*F or <https://full-of-grace-and-truth.blogspot.com/2010/01/st-anthony-and-cobbler.html?m=1>

sang the Sanctus with the angels." (Saying 24, Alphabetical Collection of the Sayings of the Desert Fathers)

any one of us would carry and nurse him even if he was not her son. We are in one living arrangement, the unity of opinion is our model, and our husbands work as shepherds. We are poor and only have our daily bread, and what is left over, we give to the poor and needy." Rejoicing, he bade them farewell. Reflecting upon the comfort of the Holy Spirit to all those who loved the Lord, his soul was filled with compassion once again, and he returned to his beloved desert.

<https://www.suscopts.org/resources/literature/181/st-macarius-the-great-clothed-with-the-holy-spirit/>

'You are mad, you are not like us. '" (Saying 25, Alphabetical Collection of the Sayings of the Desert Fathers)

argue that this was not an ordinary life. She was just a married woman. She was a great struggler, and when the time came for her to make a witness because she had struggled so often, she did something extraordinary. She is commemorated 01-03.

St Emilia of Cappadocia was the daughter of St Macrina, the Elder. Emilia married Basil (later glorified as St Basil the Elder). She had ten children, five of whom became saints: Basil the Great, Gregory of Nyssa, Peter of Sebaste, Macrina the Younger, and Theosebeia the Deaconess.

distributed to you, the civil calendar date is large and bold, and the church calendar date is beside it, with gray ink.

It's pretty easy to figure out the difference in the calendars when you're not at the beginning or end of the month. You take the civil calendar, and you subtract 13 days, and that's the Julian calendar date. Or going the other way, if you want to know what the civil date is for a church feast, add 13 days. This is confusing. We all celebrate the Nativity of the Lord on December 25. However, our December 25 on the Julian calendar is 13 days after December 25 on the civil calendar. Therefore, we celebrate Christmas on December 25, +13 days which equals January 7 on "Joe's garage calendar."

together and are equal; is this also the same between Greek Orthodox, Russian Orthodox, and other Orthodox will meet?"

In the Orthodox Church, all bishops are considered to be absolutely equal. Each bishop has sole authority in his diocese. There might be Bishops that are older or are in charge of larger dioceses, and therefore they may have more influence, but they have no right to do anything in any diocese except their own. My understanding of Roman Catholic theology is that the Pope is considered the highest bishop and has authority over every other bishop. I think that he appoints all Cardinals. That never happens in our church. We have bishops, archbishops, and metropolitans, but these are just honorary titles, and if the bishop is given one of these titles, it is assigned by the entire synod of which he is a part. For instance, if a Russian bishop is elevated to the rank of Metropolitan, the bishops of the whole Russian Church will have voted to do this.

In Orthodoxy, we have the concept of local churches. All local churches are part of one church; however, each local church governs itself as it sees fit. For instance, there is the Russian Orthodox Church, the Serbian Orthodox Church, the church of Jerusalem, Antioch, etc. When multiple bishops from multiple local churches meet, we consider seniority (determined by the date of ordination and title (Bishop, Archbishop, etc.)) to be the prime criterion for how bishops would serve together. Everyone is equal, and each bishop has exclusive authority in his diocese; however, when multiple bishops come together, there must be some way to order things.

“Is there no union/communion between the different Orthodox faiths?”

Any canonical bishop in a local Orthodox Church is in communion with all other canonical bishops in all other local churches. Therefore, I would never use the term Orthodox “faiths,” or rather, I would say the Orthodox “faith,” using the singular. There is one church, and one baptism, and one faith.

In non-dogmatic or even anti-dogmatic and ignorant days, sometimes people don’t know where the Orthodox Church is and where it isn’t. For instance, the Orthodox Church has accepted seven ecumenical councils, and some groups are honorable people that have not done so. I’m thinking of the Copts or the Ethiopians. They call themselves the Coptic Orthodox Church or the Ethiopian Orthodox Church, but we are not in communion with them. We have a dispute with them regarding the natures of Christ. We are not in communion with Roman Catholics because of the great schism and things that have happened since then. We can have mutual respect for one another, and indeed we should, but we also should not whitewash our differences in faith.

Unfortunately, we should also be aware that sometimes those who call themselves Orthodox and are even bishops or priests are affected by the world’s madness. We must be cautious regarding the teachings we hear and believe. For instance, some Orthodox priests and bishops teach that God blesses aspects of the LGBTQ lifestyle. Some are in full communion

with the Coptic Orthodox or other groups. Some have a false view of baptism and the form of baptism outside of the church. Some pray with heretics regularly. Everything must be tested against what the church is always done and believed.

We should not be dismayed by this. It’s always been this way that some call themselves one thing, yet they are another. May God forgive all bishops and priests who misrepresent the Orthodox faith.

If you are dismayed by this and consider that there are too many traps and snares in the world because it’s hard to know who is telling the truth, read about St. Anthony again and know that we are saved through humility. If you are struggling to follow the truth, you will live in it. We know the truth by experiencing the truth. Truth is not an idea or concept. The truth is a person; Jesus Christ. When we enter into the life of Christ by becoming like Him, we will not be confused.

Comparing Roman Catholic vs. Orthodox practices

“Is there a specific belief or practice which is agreed by all Orthodox to be different than Roman Catholic?”

There are many practices and dogmas in the Orthodox Church which differ from Roman Catholic. Above, we just talked about bishops. We are adamant that the authority of each bishop in his diocese is absolute. Roman Catholic model is that the Pope is the arch-pastor of all bishops, and he has complete authority in certain matters. For instance, there is the Roman doctrine of “Papal infallibility.” It states that when a Pope declares something “ex-cathedra,” it is impossible for him to be in error, and it is obligatory for all Christians, not only Roman Catholics but anyone who has any Christian belief, to believe what he has declared. We have no Orthodox bishop who can declare doctrine for the rest of the Orthodox Church. Our highest authority in the church is the Ecumenical Council. In those councils, the entire church spoke through all of its bishops.

There are other doctrinal differences. For instance, in the Symbol of Faith, we say that the Holy Spirit proceeds “from the Father,” whereas the Roman Catholics (and most Protestants, who may have left Roman Catholics, but they adhere to many of their doctrines) included the phrase “and the son.” This is very important to us. We consider the addition of the words “and the son” to be a heresy. Some people called this the Filioque heresy because that word in Latin means “and the son.”

There are many other differences between Orthodox doctrine and practice and Roman Catholics. Just to mention a few, there are differences regarding purgatory, limbo, the immaculate conception, original sin, and many other things. It would take a long time to describe all of them, but this is just a short letter. I’m happy to go into more detail if you want me to.

Priest Seraphim Holland

A Word from Fr David.

"Grant Us, O Lord, to Make a Good Beginning..."

What a year this has started out to be! A snowstorm in February with statewide power outages. I pray you all fared alright.

As Orthodox Christians, we have a bit of perspective on these events illumined by our understanding of God's providential care over all - which is especially made manifest in the Scriptures and Lives of Saints - and so we should not be shaken by them to give up on our daily "non-negotiables" (as

Fr. Seraphim memorably discussed in a recent newsletter). What do we do when these things happen? We live as Orthodox Christians: praying, repenting, fasting, serving others in need, forgiving, and asking forgiveness. Whatever this year holds, may it at least be filled with these Christian activities- and then it will be a good year, perhaps the best we have yet lived! May God grant!

With prayer and sorrow of heart for all who suffered grievous effects of the storm, my family and I also thank God for His many mercies toward us. We were only inconvenienced a bit but suffered no real hardships. My family and I played in the snow, ate dinner and played a board game by flashlight, got out the sleeping bags- and even the chickens came out in the snow! Speaking of which, we now have a rooster, four hens, and 3 chicks. Glory to God for all things!

Lent has nearly begun. A bright sorrow fills this season, and it is my favorite of the Church year - true for most Orthodox Christians, I think. We journey toward Pascha as unprofitable and unworthy pilgrims, but still, we go with hope in Christ, the Passover Lamb, desiring that He receive us and invite us to the feast of His sacrificial love. Let's make a good beginning with His help, fasting not just from food (in accordance with the Church Calendar prescriptions, as strength and circumstance permits), but even more: fasting from evil speech, ugly thoughts, cruel deeds, self-will, laziness, impure passions, wasteful and harmful entertainment and distractions, and unforgiveness and resentment toward others. Let us offer God the firstfruits of repentance: obedience, mercy, charity, kindness, and humility. Don't forget the prayer of St. Ephraim the Syrian, to be included in your daily prayers for all the days of Lent beginning the evening of Sunday, March 14, which is found on Page 171 of the full Prayer Book (Jordanville), and Page 64 of the pocket-edition Prayer Book and Psalms (Jordanville).

O Lord and Master of my life.

Prayer of St Ephrem explained

The "Prayer of St Ephrem" is ubiquitous during Great Lent and is used in all weekday services and prayers at home.

This prayer is much like the "Our Father" in the following way. When the disciples asked the Lord to teach them to pray, He told them to "pray in this way" and then recited the "Our Father," thus giving us a model for how to pray and a prayer that perfectly fulfilled these principles. So, should we treat the prayer of St Ephrem. Its content is truly sublime and teaches us the right way to approach God in prayer, how to think of ourselves, and what to ask. It also is a perfect prayer fulfilling these principles.

Everyone should say this prayer daily during the week in Great Lent.

Because of the physical way we say this prayer (it is done with bows and prostrations), it has the remarkable ability to put the soul in the right frame of mind. One might even go so far as to say that if the Prayer of St Ephrem has been prayed **with attention** at least once during the day, and nothing else has been done, the Christian has prayed well.

The reality of our scattered, busy, distracted, and often lazy lives is that we do not pray often enough, or with enough attention, or in the proper frame of mind. If a person is consistent in praying the prayer of St Ephrem, no matter how well he does in other prayer and spiritual reading, he has a "lifeline." He is grounded in the most critical aspects of the way a Christian should conduct himself during Lent.

Of course, to only pray the prayer of St Ephrem is NOT enough for a Christian, but as the saying goes: "baby steps for baby feet" We all are in some measure "babies," and all of us should pray this prayer, attentively, and carefully, without fail. The person who takes this advice to "come and see" will soon find the fruit of this practice.

This prayer entreats God to grant us all that we need to complete the Lenten journey in a Christian manner. Without it, you won't make it.

When will I be allowed to see you again? When will services and study groups resume on the unit? I've been thinking about this of late, and it seems to me that St. Mary of Egypt gives us a clue. Each Lent, we read in her life story that she couldn't enter the Church to venerate the True Cross because of her life of debauchery and whoredom and destructive self-will; realizing this, she cried out to God and the Mother of God, begging forgiveness and promising with all sincerity to make a good beginning. Mary was then granted entry into the Church, venerated the Cross, Confessed and Communed, and fulfilled her vow, departing at the command of the Theotokos into the desert beyond Jordan to spend 40 years in repentance and prayer.

When we have accepted that we, the sinners, are responsible for this time of separation and spiritual famine: When we have repented from our whole heart for the sins of our past and present, and even of our entire nation, which has brought God's righteous judgment to bear upon us: When we have passed through the open doors of repentance at the gateway to Lent and taken up the cross of fasting and prayer: Then I am assured that God, in His great mercy, will open the doors of the prison again to family and volunteers. Lord Jesus Christ, have mercy on us and save us!

The prayer of St Ephrem is found in any complete Orthodox prayer book. For instance, the "Jordanville prayer book" has this prayer in its Triodion section (page 166 in the latest printing). [Our website](#) has it in English and Slavonic with four sections per page to be printed, cut in quarters, and inserted in a prayer book in [RTF](#) and [PDF](#) formats. It is part of a dedicated page containing information about our [Theology, Homilies, Services, and other Resources about Great Lent](#).

Other resources for this prayer include a [catechetical talk about the prayer of St Ephrem](#).

Like anything worth doing, the prayer of St Ephrem takes some practice before we can receive the full benefit. There are bows AND prostrations during the prayer and a certain number of repetitions. To someone accustomed to this prayer, the physical actions and specific repetitions free the mind and penetrate the soul. This can only be understood if it is done; else, a person will consider the prayer to be too complicated, or worse, an example of "vain repetition," which the Scripture forbids.

He who has ears to hear, and mouth to speak, arms to make the sign of the cross, and knees to bend, let him understand!

The prayer of St Ephrem is said two different ways in the church. The best way to say it at home is the “longer” way, twice a day, in morning and evening prayers. If a person is not organized or motivated enough to say the formal morning or evening prayers, at least this prayer can be said. As my father used to say, Once or twice, but never “nunce”!

This is the “long way.”

- The prayer is said two times, one time in parts and the last time in full.
- After each part or the entire prayer, a prostration is made.
- Between the two, “O God cleanse me a sinner” is said twelve times, with a bow each time.
- This is easy to remember after doing it a few times.
- **Two prayers, four prostrations, twelve bows** (and 100 calories burned).

“O Lord and Master of my life, a spirit of idleness, despondency, ambition, and idle talking give me not.” (*Prostration*ⁱⁱⁱ).

“But rather a spirit of chastity, humble-mindedness, patience, and love bestow upon me Thy servant.” (*Prostration*)

“Yea, O Lord, and King grant me to see my failings and not condemn my brother; for blessed art Thou unto the ages of ages. Amen.” (*Prostration*)

Then, twelve repetitions of:

“O God, cleanse me a sinner.” (*Prostration*)

And then repeat the entire prayer all at once:

“O Lord and Master of my life, a spirit of idleness, despondency, ambition, and idle talking give me not. But rather a spirit of chastity, humble-mindedness, patience, and love bestow upon me Thy servant. Yea, O Lord, and King grant me to see my failings and not condemn my brother; for blessed art Thou unto the ages of ages. Amen.” (*Prostration*)

A Prostration is a full bow to the ground with the knees touching the ground and the head touching or near the ground, then immediately standing back up. As the bow to the ground is begun, the sign of the cross is made. Some people touch their knees to the ground first and then bend their upper body down, and the more athletic or coordinated will practically “fall” forward to the ground with their knees and hands touching at nearly the same time. This is very similar to the familiar gym class “burpee.”

A Bow, also known as a “reverence” or “Poklon,” is when the sign of the cross is made while simultaneously bowing the head by bending at the waist. Some bow deeply and touch the ground with their right hand, and others make very shallow bows. It does not matter as long as the movement is done with attention.

Something NOT TO DO: No “waving at the air.” Some do prostrations and bows quickly or carelessly, and the sign of the cross they make looks like they are shooing away a fly. “Let all things be done in good order.”

The author has many fond memories of saying this prayer way back when, as a layman, especially in the church, or with his children. The church would be dark and lit only by candles, the priest standing in front of the royal doors. It would be very quiet, and only his voice and “swishing” sound from the prostrations or bows would be heard. Everybody would be doing the same thing at once; this was always a profoundly holy moment, and I remember sometimes thinking that I wish I would always be in this state of mind. There was a feeling that something profoundly good and important was happening. A mixture of sorrow for my personal condition and great hope in God that I really would get better some time would flood my soul. Many times I would even feel warmth. The sublime was always mixed with “real life” – sounds of grunts, heavy breathing, the sights of children making very creative prostrations. When I had to say the Trisagion prayers

immediately after, I would sometimes struggle to say them without betraying that I was out of breath!

Parents: say this prayer with your children! I know, it is sometimes a “circus,” but where are they going to learn piety if not from you? Prayer is not always neat and pretty with children, but you will be glad you went to the trouble.

Here is the most important “take-home” point: **SAY THIS PRAYER EVERY WEEKDAY IN GREAT LENT!**

Priest Seraphim Holland

¹ Romans 8:26 Likewise the Spirit also helpeth our infirmities: for we know not what we should pray for as we ought: but the Spirit itself maketh intercession for us with groanings which cannot be uttered.

² See [<http://www.orthodox.net/treblic/saints-pray-for-us+former-apostates-sinners-secret-christians.docx>] AND [<http://www.orthodox.net/treblic/saints-pray-for-us+favorites.docx>, <http://www.orthodox.net/treblic/saints-pray-for-us+favorites.pdf>] You can start doing prostrations today if you want to do them.

This document is available at <http://www.orthodox.net/greatlent/o-lord-and-master-of-my-life-prayer-of-st-ephrem-01.html>. It is also in [DOC](#) or [PDF format](#).